manuscripts found in Tipu's extensive library[13] after his death was a manuscript in Persian that became known as 'Tippoo Sultaun's Dreams', in which the highly superstitious Tipu had recorded in his own hand thirty-seven of his dreams, revealing his preoccupation with tigers as instruments for the extermination of *kaffir*s, or 'infidels', with himself as the chief tiger.

But what quickly came to be seen as the most sensational and the most notorious of all Tipu's tiger-based possessions was 'Tippoo's Tiger': a mechanical pipe-organ that when cranked emitted the growls of a tiger and the screams of its victim. This had been built to Tipu's orders to celebrate the killing by a tiger of the son of General Sir Hector Munro, the man who had vanquished Tipu and his father Hyder Ali in battle in 1781.

For the EICo, the tipping factor was not so much Tipu's continuing belligerence as his friendship with England's enemy France and his employment of French military advisers. That could not be allowed, and Napoleon's invasion of Egypt in 1798 gave Governor-General Sir Arthur Wellesley enough grounds to invade Mysore with his local ally, the Nizam of Hyderabad, culminating in the storming of Seringapatam (Srirangapatnam) in 1799 and the death in arms of Tipu, the Tiger of Mysore.

Tipu's death on 4 May 1799 was the signal for looting on a staggering scale as the victors awarded themselves vast sums in prize money from Tipu's treasury as well as jewels from the royal apartments. That treasure helped to bankroll not only the EICo in its continuing rise to power in India but also many members of the British aristocracy.